he would buckle under the invisible pressure he was holding up. There was some sort of solace to knowing the cost, and that losing hurt Daley that much too. Because, even then, I was finding it hard to articulate to myself how much it hurt me to lose. It hurt so deeply, in so many ways, even in the most meaningless situations.

I was well trained in losing too. My dad loved to compete and he never let me win at anything. I would come home from playing him at any sport and my mum would instantly know who had won and who had lost. We would be wearing it. My mum, not often moved to big displays of emotion, once threw a Monopoly board at him because he was being a ‘smug winner’. I made sure to make note, and try not to be a smug winner myself, because I knew how much losing hurt and how, even in a game of backyard football, or marbles, or a quiz, or Kwik Cricket, it found a place inside you, hollowed you out. I never needed anyone else to push it further down my throat.

Wildly inspired by Daley, I also reimagined the living room as the 110 metres hurdles, when tennis season was over, the track running around the settee and cardboard boxes fashioned as hurdles. My mum thought they were too high, that I was going to fall. I was fine, I told her, and sent her upstairs. She heard the thud seconds later and, face down, I had to admit defeat; I knew she’d heard it. ‘You were right, Mum,’ I shouted up the stairs, hearing back the sound of exaggerated rolling eyes. Daley probably had to suffer like that too once upon a time. But Mum had to determine where to draw the line between standing in my way and leaving me in danger. She had watched me, after all, even at two years old, turn down a bucket and spade for a ball to kick and throw on holiday in Wales. She knew she had no choice. She didn’t, however, take as kindly the next day, and drew the line further when she saw me using her garden laundry poles as javelins in the road outside.

At night, when she was reading to me to get me to sleep or talking me down from whatever activity to induce slumber, my mind would suddenly come alive with thoughts and questions. We would be up for hours, talking about everything and anything, my brain all of a sudden running around with questions about the world and thoughts about life. It was strange, even to me, that these moments would come out of nowhere, when I had spent all day either borderline mute or just running around madly in visions of